Reflective Essay Draft – Speculation & Self-Assessment

Assignment 1a:

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As I get closer to graduating, I've been thinking about the kind of career I want to build and what type of work will keep me motivated. My main goal is to find a job that lets me use many of the skills I've developed over the years. I'm interested in a path that combines programming—both front-end and back-end—with creative work like graphic design, video editing, and drawing. I enjoy being involved in different parts of a project, and I want a career where I can switch between technical tasks and creative ones without feeling limited.

I chose this direction because I genuinely enjoy blending creativity with technology. Designing something visually is fun, but turning that design into a working product through code gives me a deeper sense of accomplishment. When I see something I imagined come to life on a screen, it motivates me to keep learning and improving. I like the challenge of figuring out how things work, solving problems, and experimenting with new tools. This mix of creativity and logic is what makes programming exciting for me.

To succeed in this type of career, I rely on a set of tools that support both my technical and creative work. For programming, Visual Studio Code is my main workspace. It helps me stay organized and lets me work efficiently on front-end and back-end projects. GitHub is also important because it teaches me how to manage code, track changes, and collaborate with others—skills that are essential in any development job.

On the creative side, the Adobe Suite is a major part of my workflow. Programs like Photoshop, Illustrator, Premiere Pro, and InDesign allow me to design graphics, edit videos, and create illustrations. These tools help me express ideas visually and produce polished work. Having experience in both coding and design gives me a unique advantage because I understand how visuals and functionality connect.

I'm also completing a minor in business, which gives me helpful knowledge about project management, teamwork, and how creative and technical industries operate. Understanding the business side of things will help me communicate better with teams and prepare me for leadership roles in the future.

Even though I have a strong foundation, I know there are areas where I need to grow. My biggest skill gap right now is back-end development. I've used some tools like React before, but I want to become more confident with server-side programming, databases, and APIs. Strengthening my back-end skills will make me more well-rounded and open up more job opportunities. I also want to get better at combining my creative work with my coding projects so I can build more interactive and visually engaging experiences. Over the next few years, I plan to focus on improving my back-end knowledge by building full-stack projects and practicing with new frameworks. I also want to keep expanding my creative portfolio and create projects that show how I can blend design and code. Gaining real-world experience through internships or freelance work will help me understand what type of environment fits me best. Overall, I want a career where creativity and technology come together, and I'm committed to growing the skills that will help me get there.